

The Wurm That Devoured Heaven

Book One — The Runt and the Word

Chapter Two

The Unburnt

He did not die in the night.

He had given it even odds. He had gone to sleep with his head tucked against the broken curl of his own shell, with one eye half-open because the other refused to close all the way, and with the slate dimmed to a pinprick at the edge of his attention. He had expected, somewhere in the dark, to feel teeth.

Instead he woke to heat and the smell of meat going bad.

The cave was no brighter than it had been the night before — if night was the word for it, and he wasn't sure it was. The coal-colored light still came off the walls. The mother still curled her enormous body around the nest like a wall of bronze. The four siblings — and now he had time to count them properly, four others, five total, the math finally settling — were piled against her flank in a tangle of warm scaled limbs, snoring like small forges.

Vale lay where he had fallen asleep, three feet from the heap, alone.

The slate hummed once when he opened his good eye all the way, the way a phone notifies you of overnight mail.

☒ OVERNIGHT ☒
TIME ELAPSED: ~8 hours.
STATUS: Hungry. Thirsty. Alive.
+1 VIT (you did not die.)
+1 END (you slept on stone.)
+2 WIS (a sibling considered you, and did not act.)
FREE STAT POINTS: 0
(Stats are gained, not allocated.
This will change.)

He read it twice.

Stats are gained, not allocated, he thought. This will change.

It was, he decided, the most useful sentence the slate had given him so far. It told him the rules were not fixed. It told him that something — some threshold, some achievement, some convincing — would unlock

the kind of control over himself he was used to having. It also told him the slate was, in some sense, willing to *warn* him about what was coming.

He was beginning to like the slate.

He was also beginning to suspect that liking it was exactly what the slate wanted.

He filed both observations in the same slot, side by side.



Before anything else, he needed to know what he was working with.

Vale had been a man who never bought a company without reading the lease on every parking space. He extended the same patience to his own new body. He lay still, half-tucked under the shell, and ran an inventory of himself the way he had once run an inventory of a warehouse fire.

Limbs: four. Two front, two back. The front ones short and clawed, the claws still soft at the tips, useful for gripping and for the kind of work a cat does when it kneads a blanket. The back ones longer and stronger, with a second joint that bent the wrong direction, which he understood, with a small internal grimace, was the right direction for him now.

Tail: long. Longer than the rest of him. Surprisingly heavy at the base, lighter at the tip. He twitched it experimentally and almost rolled himself over.

Wings: folded against his back, leathery and wet-looking, no bigger than two playing cards stuck together. He tried to open them and got a sharp burn between his shoulder blades for the effort. The slate murmured at him.

⌘ **SKILL CHECK** ⌘

Attempted action: FLEX WINGS.

Result: DENIED.

Reason: Wings are vestigial at this stage.

Attempting to use them will tear
the membrane. Membrane will not
regrow until Stage 2.

Recommendation: Do not be in a hurry.

Noted, he thought, and let the wings settle.

Mouth: lined with teeth he hadn't earned. Forty of them, by his tongue's count. Some still pushing through the gum, sharp and white and alarming. He could feel where he would, given time, bite very hard. He

stored that knowledge for later.

Eyes: two. One worked. The other — the right one — opened, but the lid stuck halfway. He worried at it with a careful claw and the lid came the rest of the way. The light hurt for a moment. Then it stopped hurting.

Size: he was, he estimated, the length of a man's forearm. The weight of a heavy book. The smallest of his siblings was twice him. The bronze one — the favored, the shrieker — was probably three times him by now.

He cross-checked against the slate.

⌘ STATUS ⌘
NAME: Ashk (the name another gave you)
RACE: Dragon (Hatchling)
STAGE: 0 — HATCHLING (day 2 of 7 ±)
VIT: 3 (+1)
STR: 1
AGI: 3
END: 3 (+1)
INT: 16
WIS: 16 (+2)
WORD: 1 (sealed)
SKILLS: none
TITLES: [Soul Out Of Place],
[The Unburnt]
WORDS HELD: 1 / 1 (sealed)
DEVOUR SLOTS: 0 / 1 (unlocked at first kill)

He stared at the last line for a long time.

Devour Slots, he thought. *Unlocked at first kill.*

So I have to kill something.

Of course I do.

He understood, the way he had once understood the structure of a leveraged buyout, that the slate was offering him a deal. Eat something it considered a kill, and a new mechanic opened. He didn't know yet what *Devour* did. He suspected, from the way the word sat heavy in the corner of his attention, that he would not like it. He also suspected he would use it anyway.

He had used many things, in his old life, that he had not liked.



The mother stirred at what he was beginning to think of as morning, though there was no daylight and no clock.

She uncoiled with the slow, deliberate menace of something built to take up space. The siblings tumbled off her flank in a complaining heap, bronze and copper and orange and red, all of them awake and shrieking before they had even opened their eyes. She made a low noise that was almost a chuckle. She moved out of the nest.

Vale, in the shell-shadow, did not move.

She returned with a deer.

Or what had been a deer. There was no head left, and only one back leg, and most of the chest cavity had been opened in transit. She dropped it

in the center of the nest and the siblings fell on it the way pigeons fall on a dropped crust, except louder, and with teeth.

Vale watched them eat.

He had a strategy. He had spent a great deal of his sleep working it out. The strategy depended on three observations:

First: the bronze one ate first, ate most, and ate without looking up. The bronze one was a problem, but a slow-moving problem; until the carcass was bare, the bronze one would be occupied.

Second: the two near-twins fought each other more than they fought anyone else. They were a pair the way some men are a pair — neither would let the other go first, and each ate watching the other rather than the meat.

Third: the far one, the smallest of the four others, was cautious. The far one waited for the others to start before it came near. The far one was, in some quiet way, also a runt — just less of one than him.

Vale waited until the bronze one had its whole head buried in the deer's chest, until the near-twins were locked over a shoulder joint, until the far one was working on a hind leg with the focused industry of an animal who had decided no one was going to fight him for it.

He waited for the copper one.

The copper one was watching him. He had known the copper one would be.

The copper one was not eating.

Of course you aren't, Vale thought. You're waiting for me to break cover. You're waiting for me to leave the shell. You want me out in the open and away from her.

He understood the copper one with the easy clarity of a man who had grown up with brothers.

He had a counter-move.

☒ ☒ ☒

He made a small sound.

Not a shriek. He couldn't have managed a shriek, and a shriek would have drawn the wrong attention. He made a thin, plaintive, broken-something chirp. The kind of noise an injured animal makes when it has given up on being saved and is just complaining for the record.

The mother's head turned.

Not toward him. Toward the *noise*. She knew where the weakest thing in her nest was; her attention slid over him without seeing him exactly, the

way a man's attention slides over a stain on his own ceiling.

But she looked. And while she looked, the copper one — who had begun to creep, very slowly, around the edge of the nest toward Vale's blind side — froze.

Froze, and looked very carefully innocent.

The mother considered the situation. The mother lost interest. The mother went back to surveying the nest at large with the patience of a thing that had nothing to fear and no schedule to keep.

But the copper one did not move again.

Vale, in the shell-shadow, did not smile. He did not have the face for it. But the slate, at the back of his mind, gave one small pleased pulse, like a parent watching a child set the table correctly for the first time.

⌘ **SKILL UNLOCKED** ⌘

[FEIGN WEAKNESS] Passive. Rank 1 / 5.

You have used your perceived weakness to redirect a predator's attention.

Effect: Creatures of significantly higher power class will, when you appear pitiful and harmless, instinctively discount you as a threat or a meal.

Effect weakens once an observer has seen you act otherwise. Do not be clever in front of witnesses you want to keep using this on.

Now there's a useful one, Vale thought. I've been running that scam since I was nine.

He had eaten his way through three decades of underestimation. Apparently the universe had a name for it now.

⌘ ⌘ ⌘

He still had to eat.

He had given himself one goal for the day: get protein into his body, increase his STR by even a fraction, and survive until evening. He couldn't fight for it. He couldn't outrun anyone for it. He had to *find* it.

He found it where any boardroom predator would have found it. Where no one else was looking.

The deer carcass was being torn from above. The bronze one and the near-twins worked the meat from the top down, ripping at ribs and flank. The far one had a back leg. The mother, when she ate at all, ate from the inside — she'd already cracked the chest and licked out what mattered to her there.

But the underside of the deer, where it lay against the matted hair of the nest, was still untouched. A long strip of belly meat. Soft. Accessible. Pressed into the floor.

And invisible from above.

Vale, when the siblings were all distracted by a particularly vigorous argument over a shoulder blade, crept along the floor of the nest on his belly. He moved the way he had moved through boardrooms — slowly, never directly toward the prize, never at a pace that drew the eye. He reached the deer. He pressed his small head under the lip of its belly. He bit.

He had never bitten anything before.

The taste was a shock so total he almost let go.

It wasn't bad. That was the shock. It was *good*. It was the goodness of a thing he had never wanted and now wanted with an animal clarity that bypassed Vale Corren entirely and came from a creature he was only beginning to be. Iron. Salt. The warm wet inside of another animal. He shuddered, and then he ate.

He ate fast. He ate quietly. He ate until his stomach — a stomach he had not known he had until it was full — was tight against his ribs, and then he ate two more bites because he didn't know when the next meal would come.

The slate, very quietly, ticked something upward.

⊠ **FEEDING** ⊠

+1 STR (raw meat, in quantity.)

+1 VIT (your body is willing to grow,
if you give it material.)

DEVOUR SLOTS: 0 / 1 (scavenged meat
does not qualify. A kill does.)

OBJECTIVE (Optional, Tier 1):

Identify which sibling will try to
kill you first. ⊠ COMPLETE.

Reward: +3 INT, +1 skill slot.

+3 INT

+1 SKILL SLOT

He read the page slowly, very slowly, the way he had once read the line of a contract that contained an embedded poison pill. Three points of INT, freely. A skill slot, freely. The slate was paying him for noticing the copper one.

You're a generous tipper, he thought, at the slate. What do you want from me in return?

The slate did not answer.

He hadn't really expected it to.



It happened on what he had decided to call the third day.

He had decided to call it the third day because the mother had left twice and come back twice, and because on each of her absences the cave had gone slightly cooler, and on each of her returns it had gone slightly warmer. He didn't trust the count, but the slate didn't correct him, so he kept it.

He had spent the time observing. By the third day he knew which sibling slept on which side of the heap. He knew which corner of the nest the mother used to relieve herself, and how she shoveled the waste into a crack in the floor with the side of one back claw, and how the crack went somewhere deeper that he couldn't see. He had marked, mentally, the two cave-mouths he could see from the nest: one large, one small, both gusting different temperatures of air.

The small one, he had decided, was his eventual exit.

He hadn't decided yet how to use that information. He had only decided to have it.

He was filing the second cave-mouth's draft pattern — the small one breathed in for a long count, out for a short — when the copper one came for him.

It was a good attempt. He gave the copper one credit, even later. The copper one waited until the mother had been gone for a while. The copper one waited until the bronze one had eaten its fill and gone back to sleep. The copper one waited until the near-twins were locked in one of their endless squabbles on the far side of the nest. The copper one waited, in short, until there was no one to see.

Then the copper one moved.

It moved in a straight line at him, low and fast, with its wing-stubs tucked tight against its back and its jaw already open. Vale saw the open jaw and understood, with the cold professional clarity he had always reserved for the most interesting moments of his life, that the copper one had been thinking about this exact attack since the moment the mother had named him Ashk.

The copper one had been planning, too.

Good for you, Vale thought, with something that, in his old face, would have been a smile.



Vale's plan for this had three layers.

Layer one: he could not win a fight. He was smaller. He was weaker. He had soft claws and a body that had never been used for anything. If the copper one got its teeth on him, he was dead.

Layer two: the copper one was committed to the attack. The copper one had chosen a window — a brief, witness-free window — and the copper one would not abort. That meant the copper one was, for the next two heartbeats, behaving predictably.

Layer three: the nest had a feature.

The feature was the crack.

The mother used a crack at the far edge of the nest to dispose of waste. Vale had watched her do it three times. The crack was narrow at the top and widened below, and it went down into the rock farther than any of the hatchlings could see. It was, in effect, a hole. A pit. A place where a thing could fall and never be found, because the mother kept dropping things into it on purpose.

The crack was directly behind Vale.

He had been sleeping with his back to it for two days for exactly this reason.

The copper one came at him low and fast and did not, of course, see the crack. The copper one saw the runt, the easy meal, the thing it had

decided to be the size of by tomorrow.

Vale waited.

He waited until the copper one was committed. He waited until the copper one's front claws had left the ground and its weight had shifted forward and its jaw was opening for the bite.

Then he did the only thing he could do.

He fell sideways.

He didn't dodge. He didn't roll. He didn't fight. He let his small wet body go completely limp, the way a possum goes limp, and dropped to the floor of the nest at the precise moment the copper one expected him to be standing there.

The copper one, committed, came through the space he had occupied, jaw open, claws out, momentum already past the point of stopping.

Behind Vale was the crack.

The copper one's front claws scrabbled. Found nothing. Found edge. Found, briefly, the rim of a hole. The copper one's body weight was already over its center of gravity; its wing-stubs flared, useless, and its mouth — open for a bite it could no longer take — issued a noise Vale would remember for a long time.

It was not a shriek. It was not a roar. It was a small, surprised, almost-thoughtful sound. A sibling sound. The sound, Vale thought, of someone who had not expected to lose.

The copper one went into the crack.

It scrabbled. It tried to catch the rim with its hind claws. The rim was smooth. The mother had used it for years. The rim was *polished*.

The copper one slipped.

The copper one went down.

There was a wet thump from somewhere far below. Then a smaller one. Then silence.

Vale lay on his side in the nest, breathing too fast, and watched the rim of the crack for a count of forty. Nothing came back up.

The slate, very quietly, lit up at the back of his mind.

☒ **FIRST KILL — RECORDED** ☒

Method: Environmental hazard.

Force used: None (legally: none).

Witnesses: None.

Target: Sibling, copper-line.

Target name: Ruun (assigned by parent).

Target stage: 0 — HATCHLING.

+5 INT

+2 WIS

+1 STR

+1 AGI

DEVOUR SLOTS: 0 / 1 ☒ available.

(You did not touch it. The world did the
work for you. The world will remember
the favor.)

His name was Ruun, Vale thought.

He was surprised to be surprised by that. He had killed men he'd known the names of, in his old life. He hadn't done it with his own hands, but the line between hiring it done and doing it yourself, he had always told himself, was a line for other people.

He held the line in his mouth for a moment and discovered, with a small dry surprise, that he didn't actually feel anything. Ruun had come at him. Ruun had been the first thing in this new world to try to end him. Ruun had failed.

Ruun had been a problem. The problem was solved.

He filed Ruun's name in the slot where he had once filed his brother's, and lay back against the broken shell, breathing.

☒ ☒ ☒

The slate had one more thing to say.

☒ DEVOUR ☒

Slot 1 of 1: AVAILABLE.

You have a confirmed kill. You may consume any portion of the body to load this slot.

DEVOUR is not eating. Eating gives you calories. Devour gives you PROPERTIES.

If you consume part of a creature with the intent to keep it, your body will integrate what was strongest about that creature.

Costs: one slot (per kill).
permanent dietary preference shift.
memory of the thing inside you.

[ACCEPT] or [DECLINE — wait for
a worthier kill]

Vale read it twice.

Then he read it a third time.

Properties, he thought.

He understood, the way he understood most things, by analogy. The slate was offering him an upgrade slot. One per kill. Spend it on the body of the kill and inherit something about that body. The cost was a slot — finite, presumably — and a *permanent dietary preference shift*, which sounded innocuous until you read it twice and realized the slate was telling him that whatever he ate would change what he wanted to eat afterward.

And the third cost. *Memory of the thing inside you.*

He thought about that for a long minute. Then he thought about it for another.

Ruun, he reminded himself, had tried to kill him.

Ruun had been faster than him. Faster than him by a wide enough margin that, if not for the crack, Ruun would have closed the distance and ended this story before Chapter Three. The *property* the slate was offering him, in Ruun's body, was almost certainly speed.

He needed speed.

He thought about the third cost again. *Memory of the thing inside you.* The slate, he was beginning to learn, was honest in a particular way. It told him exactly what he was buying. It did not sand the corners. If he

did this, he would carry Ruun, in some form, for the rest of his life.

Vale Corren considered this with the cool patience of a man who had spent his old life acquiring things he hadn't liked but had needed.

Accept, he thought.

He crawled, very carefully, to the rim of the crack.

It was a long way down. He could see Ruun far below, broken across a tongue of rock, one back leg still twitching with the last of whatever ran his body. The copper scales caught the coal-light and threw it back, beautiful in the way that broken things are sometimes more beautiful than whole ones.

Vale couldn't go down there. He'd never come back up.

But the slate had been very specific. *Any portion of the body.*

He looked around the rim of the crack. The mother had used this hole as a midden for what looked like years. The lip was greasy with old residue. And in a small crevice, just below the edge — where a long tongue, perhaps, had once flicked grit out of the rim and missed — there was a curl of fresh copper.

A single scale. Knocked loose in Ruun's fall.

Vale stretched his neck over the edge. He took the scale in his teeth. He pulled it back.

He swallowed it.

☒ ☒ ☒

It hurt.

Not the way teeth hurt. Not the way a wound hurt. The pain was internal and structural, the way a building hurts when its foundation shifts to settle deeper. He felt the scale go down and lodge somewhere it shouldn't have lodged — not the stomach. Somewhere behind the stomach. Somewhere closer to whatever it was that ran him.

He felt heat. Then he felt cold. Then he felt, very specifically, his own legs.

All four of them, in a new way.

The muscles of his hindquarters fired once, hard, without him asking. He kicked out at empty air and the kick covered more ground than it should have. The claws of his back legs flexed and he understood, in the new way the slate was teaching him to understand, that what he had inherited was not a number on a page but a *knowing* — an instinct in the meat of him, a memory the meat had now.

How to run.

He hadn't known how to run, before. He knew now. He knew the way Ruun would have known — without thinking about it, without deciding to know.

The slate confirmed.

☒ **DEVOUR — INTEGRATED** ☒

Devoured property: [Hatchling Burst]

Inherited from: Ruun, copper-line.

Effect: Short-distance speed in your stage

is now equal to the strongest of
your clutch.

Long-distance speed unchanged.

+3 AGI

Dietary preference: Copper-line meat now
reads to you as HOME.

This is a tell. Hide it.

Memory: You will remember Ruun's small,
surprised, almost-thoughtful sound
for the rest of your life.

The slate does not apologize for this.

The slate is not built to apologize.

Vale read the memory line twice.

Fine, he thought, at last.

I have made many trades for less.

He crept away from the rim of the crack on his new, slightly-faster legs, and curled himself against the side of the nest where the mother could not quite see him, and let his eyes close.

He had killed his first sibling. He had eaten — in the slate's particular sense of the word — for the first time. He had taken Ruun's speed.

Four siblings left.

The slate, on the way to sleep, gave him one last small page. He almost missed it.

⌘ **TITLE EVOLVED** ⌘

[The Unburnt] ⌘ [The Unburnt Who
Took a Brother]

Effect 1: (unchanged.)

Effect 2: Hostility from remaining kin
increases by a small amount.

Something in them knows.

Effect 3: When you are the smallest thing
in a room and the room contains
someone you have already buried,
you may move without being seen.

Note: Your kin do not know what you have
done. Their bodies know.

*So they'll know, Vale thought, in the dark behind his closed eye. Not with
their heads. With whatever it is the slate is talking to.*

Fair enough.

He listened, for a long quiet moment, to the breathing of his remaining
siblings — the bronze one, the near-twins, the far one — and tried to
feel whether any of them had begun to know.

He couldn't tell.

He suspected he would learn to.

— end of chapter —